

The Seven (Plus One) Substantive Elements of Religion

A brief narrative overview — Ninian Smart's seven dimensions, with an eighth element added.

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- 1. The Social Dimension.** Every religion is embodied in people. The social dimension covers both the sacred and charismatic personages around whom a tradition gathers, Jesus, the Buddha, Muhammad, and the actual institution that those people constitute, the Church, the Sangha, the umma, with its clergy, orders, and laity. It is this dimension that carries a religion across the generations. In Catholicism, for example, the whole structure of popes, bishops, priests, religious orders, and lay faithful is the social body through which the tradition has survived two thousand years. Note that Smart's substantive description already contains a functional attribution: the social institution exists so the religion does not die with its founders.
- 2. The Ritual and Practical Dimension.** Religions are things people do, repeatedly and in prescribed ways. This dimension covers the behavioural repertoire: worship services, sacrifices, prayers, meditations, fasts, and festivals, the regular practices that constitute the religion in action. In Islam the daily rhythm is set by the five daily prayers (salat), performed at prescribed times with prescribed motions and words, plus the annual fast of Ramadan and the once-in-a-lifetime pilgrimage (hajj). Smart adds that these practices function to develop spiritual awareness and ethical insight, and in many traditions to bring about union with the divine. Ritual is practice, not just performance.
- 3. The Experiential Dimension.** Underneath the institutions and rituals lies *religious experience* itself, the mystical, transcendent, luminous encounter that the practices are designed to facilitate. Smart regarded this as critical: it is the visions and experiences of founders that seed whole traditions, from the Buddha's enlightenment beneath the Bo tree to Paul's experience on the road to Damascus. Otto called it the numinous; James and Maslow argued such experiences are the very bedrock of religion, common even among scientists. In Zen Buddhism the whole curriculum aims at kensho or satori, a direct experiential breakthrough — "a special transmission outside the scriptures." *Experience, not doctrine, is the origin point.*
- 4. The Narrative or Mythic Dimension.** Ritual and experience are "addressed in a certain way": they are interpreted, expressed, and handed down through stories, symbols, and myths. These narratives tell of the origin of things, the history of the gods and of key figures, and the final destiny of humanity. They are typically authorized as sacred texts, works taken to come from a higher intelligence. Their historical accuracy is beside the point. What matters is the meaning they carry. In Judaism the Exodus narrative functions this way: retold every year at Passover (a ritual reenactment), it interprets the community's entire existence as a story of slavery, deliverance, and covenant. Myth is the memory and meaning-system of a faith.
- 5. The Doctrinal and Philosophical Dimension.** Alongside myth stands doctrine: the formalized, codified intellectual content of a religion, its cosmology, theology, and statements about the nature of reality. Doctrines are produced by a tradition's intelligentsia — its scholars, priests, and elite controllers, and should be underlined as such: the Catholic doctrine of the Trinity, for instance, was hammered out by bishops at councils, and the Bible itself was selected and compiled under Constantine's sponsorship. Scholars who study only elite doctrine get an unbalanced picture of religion, missing the grassroots practice of ordinary believers. Doctrine and myth typically interlock with ritual, each reinforcing the other: the Eucharist both enacts and teaches the doctrine of Christ's sacrifice.
- 6. The Path — Aspirational, Ethical, and Legal Dimension.** This dimension supplies the map and pointer for a life: the aspiration sets the orientation and goal, the ethic specifies the conduct required to reach it, and the legal layer is the aspiration written down as enforceable law. Every tradition on record has the first two layers, the universal triad of aspiration, ethic, and goal, while the third is optional. In Hinduism the aspiration is moksha, liberation from rebirth; the ethic is dharma, duty performed without attachment to fruits (Bhagavad Gita 2:47); and the legal layer is the Dharmashastra literature, above all the Laws of Manu, hardening dharma into caste law. Functionally, the path binds the community together (social cohesion) and points it toward salvation or liberation (the soteriological function).
- 7. The Material Dimension. Religion is also stuff.** The material dimension covers the physical expressions of belief: buildings, art, artifacts, statues, rosaries, pipes, vestments, and not only human-made things, for natural features can be sacred too. Rivers (the Ganges), mountains (Sinai, Fuji), trees, and animal parts (eagle feathers) all function as components of a religion. In Hinduism the temple, the murti (image of the deity), and the Ganges itself form a single material network through which the sacred is physically accessible to devotees. The material is not decoration; it is where the invisible becomes touchable.
- 8. The Therapeutic/Healing Dimension (our addition).** To Smart's seven I add an eighth substantive element: healing. Many, though not all, religious systems contain a healing element, and it is often the place where worldview stops being theory and puts its hands on the patient. Catholicism roots itself in the healing practice of Jesus — who commissions his followers to "heal the sick" (Matthew 10:8) — and institutionalized it as the Anointing of the Sick (James 5:14-15). The Buddha organized his entire system around the elimination of stress and the cessation of suffering, casting himself as a physician: the Four Noble Truths are diagnosis, cause, prognosis, and prescription. In Indigenous North American traditions healing and religion are nearly one thing — the shaman's trance, the sweat lodge, the medicine bag, and the Midewiwin's "shooting" of the sacred migis shell all aim at restoring harmony and alignment between the sick person, the spirits, and the land.